

Images of Jain *tirthankaras* cut into the rock on the summit of Kalugumalai hill, Mankulam, near Madurai.

The Kalugumalai rock is probably best known for its striking ninth-century Pandyan temple in the form of a monolith, cut out of the rock from the top downwards, but it was also known locally as Samanamalai, ‘the hill of the *sramana*s (ascetics)’. This is because on its summit, approached by a perilously exposed walkway made up of narrow steps cut into the rock, are three caves and a water tank. Every cave is adorned with carved bas-reliefs of Jain saints along with inscriptions written in characters that to Sewell’s eye closely resembled the ancient Brahmi script of the Ashokan edicts. Unable to make any sense of the writing, Sewell simply noted the discovery in his report, which duly became part of the first volume of *Inscriptions of the Madras Presidency*. Years passed before there was any follow-up.

The same thing happened in 1897 when six more inscriptions were spotted cut into the side of a cliff beside a mountain pass known as Sultan’s Battery, which took its name from an incident in the Mysore Wars when Tipu Sultan turned a Jain temple into an armoury. In this case, the finder was the Superintendent of Police for Malabar District Fred